NEB · GRADE 11 & 12 · COMPULSORY ENGLISH

Twelve Essays *for the Thinking Student*

Model academic essays with full apparatus — hook, thesis, evidenced argument, resolution — written to the standard NEB examiners reward.

A COLLECTION OF MODEL ESSAYS

Education · Technology · Environment · Media · Migration · Tourism
Gender · Mental Health · Democracy · Culture · Enterprise · Literature

With an Essay Anatomy guide and a note on how NEB examiners mark

CURRICULUM DEVELOPMENT CENTRE, SANOTHIMI · SECONDARY EDUCATION CURRICULUM 2076

The Anatomy of an Essay

An essay is not a container for information; it is an argument with a shape. Learn the shape and the content has somewhere to go.

01 — THE OPENING

The hook earns the reader's attention

Your first two sentences decide whether the rest is read generously. A hook may be a striking fact, a short anecdote, a paradox, a question, or a vivid image — but it must be *relevant*, not decorative. Never open with a dictionary definition or with "Since the dawn of time"; both announce that you have nothing specific to say.

Weak: "Education is very important in today's world." Strong: "In a classroom in Bajhang, forty-two students share eleven textbooks — and one of them will sit the same examination as a student in Patan with a personal tutor."

02 — THE THESIS

One sentence that could be disagreed with

The thesis is the argument the whole essay exists to prove. It should be specific, arguable, and placed at the end of the introduction so the reader knows exactly what is being claimed. If nobody could reasonably disagree with your thesis, it is an observation, not an argument — and the essay will have nothing to do.

Observation: "Social media has advantages and disadvantages." Thesis: "Social media has not made us more connected but more comparable, and the cost of that comparison is paid in adolescent mental health."

03 — THE BODY

One idea per paragraph, in a fixed order

Each body paragraph should do exactly four things, in this order: state a **topic sentence** that advances the thesis; supply **evidence** — a statistic, an example, an authority, a case; **analyse** that evidence rather than leaving it to speak for itself; and **link** forward to the next paragraph. Three to four such paragraphs is the exam standard; five is the maximum before the argument thins.

The commonest structural failure is the "and also" essay, in which paragraphs sit side by side without advancing. Arrange body paragraphs so that each one depends on the one before: problem, then consequence, then response.

04 — THE CONCLUSION

Return, widen, and stop

A conclusion restates the thesis in the light of the evidence — not word for word — then widens to implication: what follows if we accept the argument? End on a strong closing thought, an image, a challenge, or a prediction. Never introduce new evidence here, and never apologise ("this is just my opinion").

05 — TRANSITIONS

The joints of the argument

Linking devices are signposts, not decoration. Use them to mark the logical relation between ideas: *addition* (moreover, furthermore), *contrast* (however, nevertheless, conversely), *cause* (consequently, therefore, as a result), *concession* (admittedly, granted that), *example* (for instance, to illustrate), *sequence* (first, subsequently, ultimately).

Vary your sentence openings. A paragraph in which every sentence begins with "Also" or "Moreover" reads like a list wearing a costume. Bury the connective mid-sentence where the rhythm calls for it: "The policy was, however, never funded."

How the Examination Rewards You

Knowing the marking logic is not cheating; it is the difference between a good essay and a good essay that scores well.

Under the National Examination Board's Compulsory English paper (subject code 0031 for Grade 11), the theory examination carries 75 marks in three hours, with a further 25 marks awarded internally by the school. The paper is built in four parts: Reading, Literature, Writing and Language. Free writing — the section in which essays are examined — carries 25 of the 75 theory marks, which makes it the single largest block in the paper after literature. In other words, one quarter of your theory result is decided by how well you can sustain an argument on paper.

THE EXAMINATION GRID

PART	CONTENT	MARKS
Reading	One unseen passage, tested through short answers, true/false/not-given and inference items	15
Literature	Short answers on prescribed texts (about 75 words) and longer answers (about 150 words)	20
Writing	Free writing: typically a formal letter or notice, a report or speech, and an essay	25
Language	Grammar items and vocabulary in context	15

WHAT EXAMINERS ACTUALLY REWARD

CRITERION	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE ON THE PAGE	WEIGHT
Content & relevance	The essay answers the exact question asked, and every paragraph serves that answer	high
Organisation	Visible introduction, developed body, distinct conclusion; one idea per paragraph	high
Expression	Formal register, varied sentence length, precise vocabulary, sparing idiom	medium
Accuracy	Subject–verb agreement, tense consistency, articles, spelling, punctuation	medium

Length & presentation	Within the word limit, legible, margins respected, paragraphing clear	low but real

THREE DEDUCTIONS STUDENTS NEVER SEE COMING

Ignoring the word limit. An essay of 200 words cannot develop a thesis, and one of 900 wastes time you need for grammar and literature. Aim for the upper half of the range: for a 250–300 word task, write about 280.

Answering the topic you prepared. Examiners set topics with a narrow angle. "Social media" and "social media's effect on adolescent attention" are different questions, and only the second earns full marks.

No thesis, no argument. An essay that lists advantages and disadvantages and then declines to choose reads as unfinished. Take a position, defend it, and concede fairly where the evidence demands it.

Note on scope: this collection follows the argumentative and discursive essay, the dominant form in NEB free writing. Expository, narrative and descriptive modes are variants of the same skeleton; the thesis simply announces what will be explained, narrated or depicted rather than what will be proved.

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ESSAY ONE · EDUCATION

The Classroom and the Country

Nepal has won the argument about access to schooling. It has not begun the argument about what schooling is for.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 600 WORDS

THESIS

Nepal's educational problem is no longer the absence of schools but the absence of consequence: a system built to certify attendance rather than to cultivate judgement, and the students with the least to fall back on pay for that distinction.

In a classroom in Bajhang, forty-two students share eleven textbooks. Several hundred kilometres of road and one shared examination separate them from a student in Patan who studies with a personal tutor and an uninterrupted internet connection. Both will be told, and will reasonably believe, that the examination is fair. The belief is not cynical; it is the necessary fiction on which a national school system runs. But a fiction maintained for long enough becomes a policy, and a policy maintained for long enough becomes a habit of mind.

The first victory deserves acknowledgement, because it was real. Within a single generation Nepal moved from a country in which most children never finished primary school to one where the great majority enrol, and where girls' enrolment has risen sharply against entrenched resistance. Classrooms were built in places that had never held one. Teachers were posted to districts that had never received a posting. Anyone who remembers the alternative should be slow to dismiss what has been achieved. Yet enrolment measures presence, not learning. Successive national assessments of student achievement have found substantial proportions of Grade 8 students performing below the expectation for their own grade in mathematics and Nepali, and the gap widens for children in community schools, for children whose home language is not Nepali, and for children in the far west. The building exists. The education inside it is thinner than the enrolment figure implies.

The second difficulty is the medium of instruction, which in Nepal has become a proxy for class aspiration. A parent in Nepalgunj who enrols a child in an English-medium school is making a rational calculation about a labour market that rewards English, and it is condescending to call that calculation foolish. But comprehension is not a matter of political preference. A child who arrives at school speaking Maithili or Tamang and is taught, from the first day, in a language spoken nowhere at home, spends the

early years translating rather than thinking. The evidence on mother-tongue-based multilingual education is unusually consistent across countries: children who begin in a familiar language learn to read faster, and they transfer to the second language more successfully, not less. Nepal's own multilingual policy gestures at this. Its classrooms rarely do.

The third difficulty is what we choose to measure, because what is measured becomes what is taught. Our examinations reward the recall of definitions, dates and diagram labels. Ask a Grade 10 student why the 1990 People's Movement succeeded, and you will often be given a year. Ask why it succeeded, and the answer thins into silence, because no question on the paper ever required it. This is not a failure of students. It is a precise and predictable response to an incentive. A system that asks only for retrieval will receive only retrieval, and then complain that graduates cannot reason.

None of this is an argument against examination. Assessment is how a poor country allocates scarce places fairly, and abandoning it would advantage exactly those families who can buy the alternatives. The argument is about what sits inside the examination, and about whether the years spent preparing for it are spent on anything a person can use. It is telling that the most ambitious students treat a foreign degree as the only credible credential, and that the country then describes their departure as a brain drain rather than as a verdict on what it offered them.

Education cannot be reduced to employability, and a nation that justifies every subject by its return on investment will eventually teach nothing that cannot be invoiced. But it must at least be more than attendance with a certificate attached. A country that teaches only to certify will produce certificates in abundance and citizens in short supply. The true measure of a classroom is not how many pass through it, but whether those who do can think clearly about the country they are about to inherit — and whether anyone ever asked them to.

ESSAY TWO · TECHNOLOGY & ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Thinking Machines, Thinking Citizens

The risk is not that machines will learn to think like us, but that we will stop bothering to.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 620 WORDS

THESIS

The danger artificial intelligence poses to a country like Nepal is not mass unemployment but the quiet acceptance of machine fluency as a substitute for human judgement — in the classroom, in the office and in public argument — and the remedy lies in what we choose to teach, not merely in what we choose to regulate.

In 2023 a schoolteacher in Kathmandu set an essay for homework and received twenty-nine submissions, of which perhaps four were written by the students whose names appeared on them. The essays were well organised, correctly spelled, and almost entirely interchangeable. The teacher's problem was not that the work was bad. It was that the work was good enough to be unarguable, and that she had no way to prove otherwise. Multiply that classroom by every classroom in the country and you have, in miniature, the dilemma that artificial intelligence has handed to education everywhere — but with particular sharpness to systems that were already testing recall rather than reasoning.

It would be dishonest to begin anywhere other than with the genuine gains, because they are considerable and they are not evenly distributed. A country with fewer specialists than it needs can now distribute fragments of expertise: a health post in Humla with a phone can obtain a differential diagnosis, a farmer in Chitwan can ask about a blight in his own language, a student in Dhangadhi can have a difficult passage explained at eleven at night. Machine translation has begun to make Nepali and its sister languages legible to software that ignored them for thirty years. For a state that has always struggled to extend services beyond the Kathmandu valley, the appeal is obvious. Any argument that begins by refusing these benefits will be ignored by the people who need them.

The difficulty lies in what these systems are actually doing. A large language model predicts the next plausible token; it does not verify, and it has no stake in being right. Its output is optimised for fluency, and fluency is precisely what a tired reader uses as a proxy for truth. The consequences are mild when a chatbot invents a citation in a school essay and severe when it invents a legal precedent in a district court, or a dosage in a rural clinic. More corrosive than any single error is the habit the technology encour-

ages: the acceptance of a confident paragraph in place of an examined one. The capacity that atrophies is not memory, which was always overrated, but the slower and more laborious capacity to hold an incomplete picture, notice what is missing, and form a judgement anyway. That is what an education is supposed to build, and it is the first thing automation makes optional.

The labour question is usually posed wrongly. The fear is that machines will take work; the likelier outcome is that they will take tasks, and redistribute what remains toward the work that requires judgement, context and accountability — the work, in short, that a transmission-belt education does not prepare anyone for. Nepal is already inside this supply chain rather than outside it: young people label training data, moderate content and handle offshore support tickets, often for foreign platforms, often on night shifts. These are real jobs and they have lifted real families. They are also precarious in a specific way, because the tasks most easily described are the tasks most easily automated, and the tasks that survive require exactly the reasoning our examinations do not test.

There is a further inequity that receives too little attention. These systems are trained overwhelmingly on English text, and the languages of Nepal appear in that corpus as a rounding error. A model that cannot read Maithili, or reads it badly, does not merely fail to serve its speakers; it makes them invisible to the institutions that increasingly rely on such tools. Add the ordinary infrastructure gap — electricity, bandwidth, devices — and the promise of leapfrogging begins to look like a promise to the already connected. Regulation matters here, but a country that consumes these systems without building any capacity to audit them will be regulated by them instead.

None of this justifies the reflexive refusal that passes for scepticism in some quarters. The technology is not neutral, but neither is it destiny, and the societies that will fare best are not those that ban the tools but those that teach people to interrogate them. That means assessment that demands reasoning rather than recall, so that a generated answer cannot pass; it means teaching students to ask what a system was trained on and what it cannot know; and it means treating digital literacy as a civic subject rather than an optional extra. The question before Nepal is not whether it will adopt artificial intelligence — it will, unevenly and soon — but whether it will do so as a customer or as a participant, and whether the citizens it produces can tell the difference between a sentence that is persuasive and a sentence that is true.

ESSAY THREE · MENTAL HEALTH

The Silence We Keep

Nepal does not lack a cure for mental illness so much as permission to speak about it.

MODE: DISCURSIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 610 WORDS

THESIS

The mental health crisis among young Nepalis is sustained less by a shortage of psychiatrists than by a culture that reads suffering as weakness and a system that funds beds rather than people; until distress can be named without shame, no expansion of services will reach those who need them.

When a young man in a village outside Butwal stopped attending college, his family did what families here have learned to do: they consulted an astrologer, then a traditional healer, then waited. He was not being neglected. He was being cared for in the only grammar his community possessed, one in which a disturbance of the mind is either a spiritual matter or a character flaw, and never simply an illness that has a name, a cause and a treatment. By the time anyone mentioned a doctor, two years had passed. This is not an unusual story. It is the standard one.

The arithmetic of provision is stark enough on its own. The World Health Organization's mental health atlas places Nepal among the countries with fewer than one psychiatrist per hundred thousand people, and the figures for clinical psychologists and trained psychiatric nurses are worse. Those specialists are overwhelmingly concentrated in Kathmandu and a handful of urban centres, which means that for most of the country the nearest qualified person is a day's travel and several days' wages away. The treatment gap — the proportion of people with a diagnosable condition who receive any care at all — is estimated at more than eighty per cent. In practice this means that the typical response to serious mental illness in Nepal is not treatment but containment, and containment falls almost entirely on women who have no training and no support.

Yet the shortage of clinicians is the easier half of the problem, because shortages can be funded. The harder half is cultural, and it begins with language. Nepali has no comfortable register for depression. The available words describe madness, or weakness, or a fault in the family's fortune, and each of these carries a social cost that a young person weighs before speaking. A student who admits to panic before an examination risks being told she is ungrateful; a son who admits to hopelessness risks being told he is not trying. Small wonder that distress expresses itself somatically — as headache, as stomach pain, as an exhaustion no test explains — because the body is a more permissible place

to suffer than the mind. The consequence is a population that presents late, presents physically, and is treated for the wrong thing.

Suicide makes the cost of that silence concrete. Nepal has one of the higher suicide rates in South Asia, and it is a leading cause of death among young women, many of them married young and living far from their own families. For decades the attempt itself was a criminal offence, which meant that a person in crisis faced the prospect of arrest upon surviving it; the reformed criminal code removed that provision, but the stigma it encoded has not been repealed. Reporting remains restrained and euphemistic, which protects families but also removes the one form of public acknowledgement that has demonstrably helped elsewhere. A country that cannot say the word will struggle to prevent the act.

Two structural pressures deserve particular mention because they are distinctively Nepali. The first is migration. When a substantial share of the working-age male population is abroad, the household left behind is not simply poorer in labour but reorganised around absence; adolescents grow up with a parent who is a voice on a screen and a decision-maker who is never in the room. The second is educational pressure in a system where a single examination allocates futures. Neither causes mental illness on its own. Both remove the slack that makes it survivable.

There are remedies, and they are not fantastical. Community mental health programmes that train existing health post staff, school counsellors with actual training rather than a nominal post, telepsychiatry that turns a district hospital into a consultation room, and curricula that teach adolescents to recognise distress in themselves and others — these are cheap relative to the cost of doing nothing, and they have worked in comparable settings. But every one of them depends on the same precondition: that a person can ask for help without first having to defend their character. The silence is the disease. The rest is treatment.

ESSAY FOUR · ENVIRONMENT & CLIMATE

The Vanishing Snow

Nepal contributes almost nothing to the problem and absorbs almost everything.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 610 WORDS

THESIS

Climate change in Nepal is not a distant environmental concern but an immediate question of water, food and survival, and the country's most urgent task is not mitigation of emissions it barely produces but adaptation for the communities already living with the consequences.

The Imja glacier, once a solid river of ice beneath Everest, has retreated more than two kilometres in fifty years and left behind a lake. That lake is growing. It is held back by a wall of loose rubble, and below it, in the valley, are villages, trails, a hydropower station and the people who depend on all three. This is what climate change looks like in Nepal: not a forecast, not a graph, but a body of water where there used to be ice, accumulating above people who have done almost nothing to cause it.

The injustice is arithmetically plain. Nepal's share of global greenhouse gas emissions is well under one tenth of one per cent, and its per capita emissions are among the lowest in Asia. The countries that have emitted the most are, by and large, the least exposed; the countries most exposed have the least capacity to adapt. Nepal sits near the top of every global index of climate vulnerability while sitting near the bottom of every index of responsibility. This is not a rhetorical flourish but a description of a transfer: the cost of industrialisation elsewhere is being paid here, in lost harvests, in washed-out roads, in the labour of women walking further each year for water.

The mechanism is water. Nepal's rivers are fed not only by monsoon rain but by snowmelt, and the snow is disappearing. In the short term this produces more water — a swollen, dangerous surplus that arrives as glacial lake outburst floods and landslides. In the long term it produces less. Hydrologists describe the pattern as a peak followed by decline, and the peak is not a comfort: it is the final abundance before the deficit. A country that generates nearly all of its electricity from run-of-river hydropower has built its entire energy future on a resource whose seasonal reliability is now in question. The same water irrigates the rice that feeds the plains. When the glaciers finish their retreat, they will not be replaced.

The human consequences are already unevenly distributed. In the high mountains, herders report pastures that dry earlier and snow that arrives later. In the Terai, the monsoon has become more erratic — fewer, heavier rainfall events separated by longer dry

spells, which is precisely the pattern that destroys soil and ruins a harvest. Each flood and landslide displaces families who were already close to the margin, and recovery is financed by borrowing or by migration. The people who leave for the Gulf because their field was washed away are, in a real sense, climate migrants, though no visa category acknowledges them.

The policy response has been earnest and largely inadequate. Nepal has committed to ambitious targets, expanded community forestry — one of its genuine successes, in which local management restored substantial forest cover — and taken a prominent role in international advocacy for climate finance. But pledges of international money have arrived slowly and mostly as loans rather than grants, which means a poor country is being asked to borrow in order to repair damage it did not cause. Meanwhile, adaptation spending is fragmented across ministries, and early-warning systems cover only a fraction of the basins that need them.

What would a serious response look like? It would treat adaptation as infrastructure rather than as aid: expanded glacial lake monitoring, embankments and slope stabilisation, drought-resistant seed, water storage that survives an erratic monsoon, and a hydropower strategy that accounts for declining flow rather than assuming the past will recur. It would also mean accepting that some villages cannot be defended and planning their relocation with dignity instead of discovering it in a flood. And it would mean that Nepal's negotiators, whose moral case is unusually strong, convert that case into grants and technology rather than communiqués.

The snow will not return within any of our lifetimes. What remains to be decided is whether the country meets that fact with preparation or with surprise — and whether the world that caused it accepts a share of the bill it has so far declined to pay.

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ESSAY FIVE · TOURISM IN NEPAL

Beyond the Postcard

Tourism has been sold to Nepal as a windfall. It is better understood as an industry that must be designed.

MODE: DISCURSIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 600 WORDS

THESIS

Nepal's tourism sector generates foreign exchange but leaks most of its value out of the country and concentrates its costs on the communities that host it; a shift from volume to value — longer stays, local ownership, and regulated trekking — would serve both the visitor and the visited far better than the current race for arrivals.

Every October, the trail between Lukla and Everest Base Camp becomes a queue. Porters carrying sixty kilograms pass trekkers carrying a daypack, yaks block the path, and the lodges at Namche Bazaar are booked months in advance. For the visitor this is a minor inconvenience and a good story. For Nepal it is a success narrative repeated in every brochure and every ministry press release: record arrivals, record revenue, record visibility. The figure is real. What the figure conceals is how little of it stays.

Tourism is frequently described in Nepal as the country's third-largest source of foreign exchange, and it employs several hundred thousand people directly and indirectly. The Himalayas are an asset no competitor can replicate; the cultural density of the Kathmandu valley, the religious sites at Lumbini, Pashupatinath and Muktinath, and the biodiversity of Chitwan and Bardia give the country a range that few destinations of comparable size can offer. After the 2015 earthquake and again after the pandemic, tourism was the sector policymakers turned to first, and with reason: it can generate income in places where there is no other industry.

But the economics leak. A large share of the money a trekker spends is captured before it reaches Nepal — by international airlines, by foreign-owned trekking agencies that book the trip, by equipment brands and by booking platforms. Of what arrives, a significant portion goes to imported goods: the pasta in a lodge at 3,800 metres, the bottled water, the fuel. Studies of tourism value chains in Nepal consistently find that a minority of total visitor spending remains in the local economy. The lodge owner in Ghandruk earns something; the woman who could sell him vegetables earns nothing, because he buys imported packets instead. Tourism as currently organised is a foreign-currency pipeline that passes through the mountains without stopping.

The costs, by contrast, are local and concentrated. Sagarmatha National Park receives tens of thousands of visitors a year into an ecosystem that cannot metabolise them;

waste management at altitude is a permanent crisis, and the practice of burning or burying refuse near trails has left a legacy that cleanup campaigns are still addressing. Trail erosion, deforestation for lodge fuel, and the pressure of numbers on fragile heritage sites in Kathmandu are all classic consequences of unmanaged volume. Culturally, the effect is subtler but familiar: villages that become service corridors for foreigners begin to perform their traditions rather than practise them, and young people learn that their culture is a product with a price.

There is also a seasonal and structural fragility that the pandemic exposed with unusual clarity. When borders closed, an estimated hundreds of thousands of workers in tourism lost their income within weeks, and many migrated abroad or returned to subsistence farming. A sector that depends entirely on arrivals from a handful of source countries is a sector that can be switched off by a decision made elsewhere. Yet the recovery since 2022 has been presented almost entirely as a return to volume, with the same targets, the same circuits and the same seasonality.

A better model is not difficult to describe. Lengthen stays rather than multiply arrivals: a visitor who stays three weeks and hires a local guide, buys local food and sleeps in a homestay distributes more value than three visitors who stay five days on a package. Formalise community homestays with training and credit so that the money reaches households directly. Regulate the high trails with permits and caps, as Bhutan and parts of Peru have done, on the principle that a resource priced at zero will be consumed until it is gone. Invest in domestic and regional tourism, which is less seasonal and less exposed to distant shocks. And enforce the waste and building codes that already exist but are rarely applied above Namche.

None of this requires less tourism. It requires a different arithmetic, in which the measure of success is not how many people arrive but how much of their spending stays, how many families it supports, and whether the mountain is in the same condition for the next generation. A postcard is a picture of a place. An industry should be a means of keeping it.

ESSAY SIX · YOUTH & MIGRATION

The Departure Lounge

Nepal calls it a brain drain. The young people queuing at Tribhuvan airport call it a plan.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 630 WORDS

THESIS

Youth migration from Nepal is not a failure of patriotism but a rational response to a labour market that cannot absorb the educated and a state that cannot protect the departing; the remedy lies less in discouraging departure than in making return worthwhile and making the departure itself safe.

On any given morning, the departures hall at Tribhuvan International Airport holds a small cross-section of a national decision. A nursing graduate bound for Japan, a young man with a labour permit for Qatar, a student with an offer letter from an Australian university and a father's land sold to finance it, a teenager who has never flown before and is holding a bag of someone else's belongings. They are not fleeing a war or a famine. They are executing a calculation, and they have executed it correctly.

The scale is difficult to overstate. Remittances account for roughly a quarter of Nepal's gross domestic product, among the highest ratios in the world, and they exceed the combined value of the country's exports and tourist receipts. More than a million labour permits are issued in a typical year, and the true figure is higher because much migration to India across an open border is unrecorded. Nepal has, in effect, exported a substantial portion of its working-age population and financed its imports and its budget with the wages they send home. No national account is more consequential and less discussed.

The standard explanation — that young people have lost faith in the country — mistakes a symptom for a motive. Consider what the domestic labour market offers a graduate. The formal sector is small, public employment is scarce and allocated through networks, and private-sector wages are low relative to the cost of living in the cities where the jobs are. Meanwhile, a care worker in Japan or a nurse in the United Kingdom can earn in a month what a similar position pays here in a year, and can expect training, contracts and legal protection. A student who chooses that path has not abandoned Nepal; she has compared two offers. The failure is not in her loyalty but in the offer.

Yet the calculus is not as clean as the wage differential suggests, because the migration industry is itself a source of harm. Nepal's labour migration is mediated by private

recruiters whose fees are frequently illegal, sometimes extortionate, and often financed by loans secured against family land. Workers arrive in destination countries with debts, without the job they were promised, and without recourse, since the contract they signed is in a language they do not read. The consequences are well documented: deaths on worksites in the Gulf and Malaysia, many classified as natural causes, passport confiscation, unpaid wages, and a return home with an injury and no compensation. The state has taken steps — a welfare fund, minimum wage floors negotiated bilaterally, a handful of banned destinations — but enforcement remains thin, and the incentive structure still rewards volume over protection.

The social costs accumulate quietly. Villages in the hills are populated by the elderly, by women managing households alone, and by children raised at a distance from one parent or both. Agriculture suffers from absent labour, and land falls out of cultivation. The women left behind often gain autonomy in practice — managing money, making decisions — while remaining subject to social expectations that do not recognise the change. Children grow up with remittances and without adults. These are not arguments against migration; they are arguments for counting its costs honestly.

What would a serious policy look like? Safe migration first: licensing and auditing recruiters, capping fees, mandating pre-departure language and rights training, and enforcing contracts through embassies that have the staff to do it. Skilled migration second: negotiating mutual recognition of Nepali qualifications so a nurse or an engineer is not forced into unskilled work abroad. Return third — and this is the neglected one: a diaspora is an asset only if there is a path back. That means recognition of foreign experience, investment instruments designed for returnees, research and teaching positions that can absorb a PhD, and a political culture that treats a returning migrant as a resource rather than a suspect.

It is sentimental, and slightly dishonest, to ask young Nepalis to stay out of loyalty while offering them so little. The honest question is different: what would have to be true for a capable twenty-five-year-old to see a future here? Answer that, and the departures hall will empty on its own.

ESSAY SEVEN · GENDER EQUALITY

Half the Sky, Half the Say

Nepal has legislated equality more thoroughly than it has practised it.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 620 WORDS

THESIS

Nepal's gender gap is no longer primarily a problem of law, which has advanced considerably, but of implementation and social expectation — and until the state enforces the rights it has already granted, formal equality will remain a promise that women carry without being able to spend.

In 2006, Nepal's Supreme Court ordered the government to recognise a woman's equal right to inherit property. In 2007, the interim constitution guaranteed proportional representation. In 2015, the new constitution made women's participation in every party's candidate list mandatory and reserved a third of local government seats for women. On paper, this is one of the more progressive legal frameworks in South Asia. In practice, a woman in much of rural Nepal still forfeits her share of the family land when she marries, still leaves her natal home with the understanding that it is no longer hers, and still lives under the expectation that a good daughter does not ask.

The gap between statute and life is the central fact of Nepali gender relations, and it is not mysterious. Laws are enforced by institutions, and the institutions that would enforce inheritance — land offices, local courts, village councils — are staffed by the same communities whose expectations the law is meant to override. A woman who claims her share of ancestral land must be willing to litigate against her brothers in a proceeding that may take years, in a district where the registrar knows her family, with the cost paid in money and in reputation. Most women calculate, correctly, that the claim is not worth the rupture. The statute costs her nothing to hold and almost nothing to enforce.

Education shows how quickly norms can shift when the incentive changes. Girls' enrolment has risen dramatically, and in much of the country girls now outperform boys in school-leaving examinations. Where scholarships, free transport and girls' toilets were provided, attendance followed; where families were shown that a daughter's schooling had an economic return, resistance softened. This is not a story of innate difference but of what happens when a barrier is removed and the surrounding expectation adjusts. Yet the same girls who excel in Grade 10 enter a labour market in which women's participation is among the lowest in the region, partly because the work available is incompatible with the domestic labour they are still expected to perform alone.

That double burden is the least visible mechanism of inequality. Nepali women perform the overwhelming majority of unpaid household work — cooking, water collection, fuel gathering, care of children and the elderly — and this work is neither counted in national accounts nor reduced by women's employment. A woman who takes a paid job adds hours rather than substituting them. The practical result is a labour market in which women are available for part-time, informal and home-based work, which pays less, offers no security, and cannot be reconciled with advancement. Chhaupadi, the practice of exiling menstruating women to outbuildings, is the most publicised expression of the underlying belief that a woman's body is a source of contamination; it was criminalised in 2017 and continues, particularly in the far west, because a law cannot reach into a shed at the edge of a village.

Political representation has produced more mixed results than expected. The reservation of local seats brought tens of thousands of women into government, and in many wards they have exercised real authority over budgets and planning. But the requirement that a woman hold the position of deputy mayor, rather than mayor, in most municipalities has created a structural ceiling, and the phenomenon of the "proxy woman" — a seat-holder whose husband conducts the business — is widely acknowledged. Representation without authority is a form of decoration, and it teaches the next generation that a woman in office is an exception to be managed.

What would real progress require? Enforcement with resources: legal aid that reaches the district level, land offices instructed and audited on inheritance claims, and police and judicial training that treats domestic violence as a crime rather than a dispute. Recognition of unpaid work in policy, through childcare provision and infrastructure that reduces the hours spent collecting water and fuel. Genuine authority in representation, not reserved deputy positions. And, most slowly, the change that no statute can deliver — the expectation, transmitted in families, that a daughter's claim is not a request.

Equality is not a gift the state confers and then forgets. It is an arrangement that has to be defended in every land office, every classroom and every kitchen where a girl is told her brother will inherit. Nepal has written the law. It has not yet decided to mean it.

ESSAY EIGHT · DEMOCRACY & CITIZENSHIP

The Fragile Republic

Nepal has held elections for three decades. It has not yet finished building a democracy.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 630 WORDS

THESIS

Nepal's democratic deficit is not electoral but institutional: the country has learned to hold elections while failing to build the accountability, decentralisation and civic participation that give elections meaning, and until those are addressed the republic will remain a procedure rather than a practice.

In 1990, hundreds of thousands of people filled the streets of Kathmandu demanding a constitution that recognised them as citizens rather than subjects. In 2006, they did it again. In 2008, the monarchy was abolished and Nepal became a federal democratic republic. In 2015, a constitution was promulgated after a decade of delay. By any measure of political change, this is a remarkable sequence — three regime transformations in a single generation, each achieved substantially through peaceful mobilisation. It is also a sequence in which the quality of governance has improved far more slowly than the form of government.

The most visible symptom is instability. Nepal has had more than a dozen governments since 1990, few of which have lasted a full term, and the pattern has continued into the federal era. Coalitions form and dissolve around the calculations of a handful of leaders rather than around programmatic disagreement; a party that leaves a coalition in the morning may join the government by evening. The cost is not merely symbolic. A minister who expects to hold office for eight months does not initiate a reform that will take five years to bear fruit. Civil servants learn to wait. Donors learn to route money around the state. The horizon of policy shrinks to the horizon of the next reshuffle.

The 2015 constitution created a federal structure with seven provinces and 753 local units, and this is genuinely the most consequential institutional reform since 1990. Devolution moved money and authority closer to citizens: local governments now control substantial budgets, and in many places a ward chairperson is more responsive to a village's needs than any Kathmandu ministry ever was. But federalism has been implemented unevenly and grudgingly. Powers were devolved on paper while the fiscal and administrative capacity to exercise them was retained at the centre; local governments often lack trained staff, and the temptation to spend on visible ribbon-cutting rather than on

maintenance is strong. Decentralisation without capacity produces a different set of failures, not an absence of them.

The deeper problem is accountability. Nepal's institutions of horizontal oversight — the Commission for the Investigation of Abuse of Authority, the Auditor General, the courts — exist and sometimes act, but they are widely perceived as selective. When corruption investigations consistently reach opposition figures and consistently stop short of the governing coalition, public trust erodes not because people have read the case file but because they have learned the pattern. Impunity at the top propagates downward: a customs officer who sees that embezzlement at ministerial level carries no consequence will not be deterred by a circular.

There is also the question of what citizenship actually involves. A democracy asks more of its people than voting every five years, and Nepal's civic infrastructure is thin: political parties that function as vehicles for individual careers rather than as organisations with members and internal debate, a media that is vibrant but financially dependent on advertising from the same conglomerates it should scrutinise, and a school system that teaches the structures of government without ever asking students to practise them. Transitional justice remains the most conspicuous failure — two decades after the conflict ended, the commissions established to investigate disappearances and abuses have delivered almost no findings, and victims are ageing without answers. A state that cannot account for its own violence cannot credibly demand accountability from anyone else.

The remedies are unglamorous and therefore rarely proposed. Strengthen parliamentary committees with real investigative staff. Publish budgets and procurement at the local level in a form a citizen can read. Make party membership and internal elections genuine rather than nominal. Give the oversight bodies security of tenure and a protected budget. Teach civic practice in schools, not civic mythology. Fund legal aid so that a citizen can challenge the state without a fortune.

Democracy in Nepal has been won twice by people who took considerable risks to obtain it. What remains is the slower work of making it deliver — and that work is done not in constitutions but in budgets, in audits, in committee rooms, in the ordinary insistence that those who hold power explain what they did with it.

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ESSAY NINE · CULTURE & MODERNITY

Between Ritual and Reinvention

The question is not whether Nepali culture will change. It is who gets to decide which parts survive.

MODE: DISCURSIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 600 WORDS

THESIS

The tension between tradition and modernity in Nepal is falsely framed as a contest between preservation and loss; cultures have always changed, and the real question is whether the change is negotiated by the people whose culture it is or imposed by markets, migration and an unexamined nostalgia.

During Indra Jatra, the chariot of Kumari is pulled through the old streets of Kathmandu by crowds whose grandparents pulled the same ropes. Alongside them, teenagers hold phones above their heads, live-streaming. In the same week, a family in the hills debates whether to perform an elaborate funeral rite that will cost more than a year's income, while a cousin in Sydney joins by video call. Both scenes are usually offered as evidence that Nepali culture is under threat. They are more accurately described as evidence that it is alive, which is to say, changing.

The preservationist anxiety is understandable and not baseless. Nepal's cultural heritage is unusually dense — a valley of temples, a calendar of festivals that structures the year, dozens of languages, textile and craft traditions of genuine sophistication — and much of it is genuinely vulnerable. The 2015 earthquake destroyed monuments that cannot be rebuilt in their original form. Kathmandu's traditional architecture has been replaced, street by street, with concrete. Languages with small speaker populations are losing their youngest generation, and with them oral literatures that were never written down. These are irreplaceable losses, and the instinct to protect is correct.

But the preservationist argument often smuggles in a second claim that does not follow: that change itself is the problem. Culture is not a fixed object that either survives or perishes; it is a set of practices that people revise as their circumstances change. The festivals of the Kathmandu valley absorbed elements of Hinduism and Buddhism over centuries and were transformed in the process. Newari architecture adapted to available materials. The caste system, once defended as immutable tradition, was abolished by law because a majority of Nepalis concluded that a tradition could be both old and wrong. Any account of culture that treats change as corruption must explain why the changes we now revere were not corruption at the time.

What is genuinely troubling is not change but the loss of agency over it. Three forces presently drive cultural change in Nepal, and none of them is democratic. The first is the market: festivals are increasingly packaged for tourists and for television, which selects the photogenic and discards the slow, the private and the mournful. The second is migration: a household with members in the Gulf and children in an English-medium school reorganises its language, its diet and its rituals around absent people, often without deciding to. The third is aspiration: modernity arrives in Nepal as a package in which certain foods, accents and weddings are marked as advanced and others as backward, and families adopt the package to avoid being looked down upon.

The result is not the disappearance of tradition but its stratification. Some practices become performance — maintained for visitors, emptied of participation. Others become identity markers, defended more fiercely as they become less practised. And some simply lapse, unremarked, because no one had time. Meanwhile, an authentic and unselfconscious culture continues to develop in the spaces no one is watching: in the music young Nepalis are making, in the Nepali language as it is written online, in the food of Kathmandu's migrant neighbourhoods, which is now genuinely syncretic.

The better question, then, is not how to keep culture unchanged but how to keep the choice in the hands of the people who live it. That means documenting languages and crafts before they go, not as museum exhibits but as living skills with economic support. It means regulating heritage tourism so that a festival is not converted into a ticketed attraction. It means teaching children the literature and history they inherit, so that discarding a tradition becomes a decision rather than an ignorance. And it means resisting the quiet cruelty of a modernity that teaches people to be ashamed of where they are from.

A culture that cannot change is already dead; it is only the embalming that remains. Nepal's traditions will survive not by being frozen but by being argued over — and the argument is healthiest when it is conducted by Nepalis, in their own languages, on their own terms.

ESSAY TEN · ENTREPRENEURSHIP

The Risk of Beginning

Nepal does not lack ambition. It lacks the boring institutions that make ambition survivable.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 620 WORDS

THESIS

Nepal's entrepreneurial deficit is not a shortage of ideas or appetite but a shortage of the unglamorous infrastructure — credit, contract enforcement, reliable power and a second chance after failure — that allows a small enterprise to survive its first three years, and policy should attend to that infrastructure rather than to startup rhetoric.

A young woman in Pokhara develops a line of trekking accessories using locally sourced dhaka fabric. The product is good. She has orders from three lodges and a growing following online. Eighteen months later she has closed, not because demand disappeared but because she could not obtain working capital at a rate that a small business can service, could not enforce payment from a distributor who owed her four months of invoices, and could not absorb a monsoon season in which load-shedding made her production schedule meaningless. Her idea was never the problem. Everything around the idea was.

Nepal's official enthusiasm for entrepreneurship is genuine and well documented: a startup policy, incubators in Kathmandu and a few other cities, youth-focused loan schemes, and a steady stream of competitions and bootcamps. The rhetoric is not wrong in principle. A country that cannot absorb its graduates into the public sector or into large firms needs new firms, and small and medium enterprises already account for the majority of employment. Encouraging enterprise is a reasonable response to a labour market that is failing to place its own educated young.

But the constraints that actually determine survival are structural, and they are not addressed by incubators. The first is credit. Nepali banks lend overwhelmingly against collateral, which means that capital is available to those who already own land and unavailable to those who do not. A young founder with a viable business and no property will be declined; a landowner with no business plan will be approved. Venture and angel capital exist but remain small and concentrated in a handful of Kathmandu networks, and interest rates on commercial borrowing are high enough to consume the margin of most small enterprises. The result is an entrepreneurial class recruited by inheritance rather than by ability.

The second is the cost of formality. Registering a business, complying with tax and labour obligations, and obtaining the permits that a workshop or a small factory requires consume time and money that a startup does not have. Informal operation avoids this but caps growth: an informal firm cannot access credit, cannot bid for contracts, and cannot enforce agreements. Nepal has improved its ranking on some measures of business regulation and worsened on others, and the practical experience of small firms remains one of unpredictable inspection and negotiated compliance.

The third, and the most neglected, is the absence of a second chance. In Nepal, business failure carries social and financial consequences that are difficult to discharge: a personal guarantee on a loan, a damaged credit history, and a family reputation that does not distinguish between misfortune and dishonesty. In economies with functioning insolvency frameworks, failure is a recognised, bounded event after which a founder can try again; roughly half of successful entrepreneurs have failed at something first. Where failure is permanent, risk-taking is restricted to those who can afford to lose everything, which is precisely the group with the least need to take risks.

There is also a cultural mismatch worth naming. Much of the entrepreneurial discourse in Nepal is imported wholesale from Silicon Valley, complete with the vocabulary of disruption and scale, and it sits awkwardly on an economy where the most valuable opportunities are unglamorous: agricultural processing, cold storage, repair and maintenance, logistics, tourism services, education. A country whose best founders are building apps for a domestic market of thirty million people with limited payment infrastructure may be misallocating its most capable people. The most transformative enterprises in comparable economies have often been boring ones that solved a physical problem.

What would actually help is unspectacular. Moveable collateral and credit guarantees so that a business can borrow against orders rather than land. Fast, predictable contract enforcement, because a firm that cannot collect a debt cannot grow. Reliable electricity, which is an industrial policy in itself. A modern insolvency law that discharges an honest bankrupt. And, at the level of schooling, an education that teaches young people to read a balance sheet and to treat failure as information rather than shame.

Entrepreneurship is often described as a spirit. It is more accurately described as a bet, and people place bets when the odds are legible and the losses are survivable. Nepal does not need more encouragement. It needs better odds.

ESSAY ELEVEN · SOCIAL MEDIA

The Performed Self

We have never been so connected, or so carefully curated.

MODE: ARGUMENTATIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 610 WORDS

THESIS

Social media has not made us more connected but more comparable: by converting social life into a public performance measured in visible approval, it has intensified status competition and damaged the attention and self-regard of the young, and the remedy lies in how we teach and regulate use rather than in the technology's abolition.

A sixteen-year-old in Biratnagar posts a photograph at nine in the evening. By eleven she has deleted it. Nothing was said; nothing needed to be said. The absence of response was itself the message, and she has learned to read it fluently. This is the ordinary texture of adolescent life in Nepal in the 2020s, and it is not a moral panic. It is a description of a new and specific kind of social pressure, one that operates continuously, publicly, and in numbers.

The benefits are real and should not be dismissed by anyone old enough to remember the alternative. Nepalis abroad maintain daily contact with families in villages that had one telephone a generation ago. Small businesses in Pokhara and Birtamod reach customers without a shopfront. Political mobilisation, disaster response during the 2015 earthquake, and the circulation of public health information have all been accelerated by these platforms. For young people in socially conservative settings, they can provide access to communities and identities that the immediate neighbourhood does not permit. Any argument that begins with abolition is an argument from a position of comfort.

But the architecture of the platforms shapes behaviour in ways their users did not choose. The feed is not a neutral window; it is a ranked sequence optimised for the time a user spends on it, which means it is optimised for arousal. Content that provokes — outrage, envy, fear, indignation — reliably outperforms content that informs. The consequence is a public sphere in which the most emotionally inflamed contributions travel furthest, and in which a user's sense of what everyone thinks is systematically distorted by what everyone is shown.

The more personal damage is comparison. Human beings have always measured themselves against others, but the reference group used to be bounded: a village, a school, a workplace. Social media replaces that with a curated global sample in which every participant presents an edited maximum — the best photograph of the best day. A

user comparing her ordinary Tuesday with a stranger's highlight reel is not being irrational; she is responding correctly to a sample that has been selected to produce exactly this effect. The documented result among adolescents is a rise in anxiety, in body dissatisfaction, and in the sense of falling behind a race that no one agreed to run.

Attention is the quieter casualty. The average user checks a phone within minutes of waking, and the design of the product deliberately rewards this: variable rewards, infinite scroll, notifications engineered to pull a person back. What is lost is not simply time, though it is that, but the capacity for sustained thought — the state in which a difficult text, a problem or a conversation is allowed to remain unresolved long enough to be understood. A generation that has never sat with a book for two uninterrupted hours has not lost a habit. It has lost a way of thinking.

There is a specifically Nepali dimension. With a substantial share of young men working abroad, these platforms have become the primary medium of family life, and they carry the emotional weight of a relationship conducted at a distance. They are also increasingly where political argument happens, in a country where the mainstream press is financially vulnerable and trust in institutions is low. A public sphere that migrates to platforms optimised for outrage does not become more democratic; it becomes louder and less capable of agreement.

The remedies are unfashionably modest. Teach media literacy as a compulsory skill — how a feed is ranked, how an image is edited, how an outrage economy works — because an informed user behaves differently. Regulate the design features rather than the content: algorithmic transparency, limits on engagement optimisation for minors, and default settings that favour deliberation over arousal. Protect attention in schools by removing phones from classrooms, not as punishment but as policy. And, at the level of the individual, recover the practice of being unreachable for part of the day.

Social media is not a disease and it will not be abandoned. But a tool that measures its own success by the hours it removes from your life deserves more scepticism than the generation that grew up inside it has been encouraged to apply.

ESSAY TWELVE · LITERARY & REFLECTIVE

The Book That Reads Us

On rereading, and the strange discovery that the text has changed since we last met it.

MODE: REFLECTIVE · NEB FREE WRITING · SUGGESTED LENGTH: 590 WORDS

THESIS

A book read twice is not the same book, because the reader who returns to it is not the same reader; rereading is therefore less an act of nostalgia than a form of self-examination, and it is one of the few ways we have of measuring who we have become.

I first read *The Great Gatsby* at seventeen, in a classroom in Kathmandu where the windows were open and the fan did not work, and I thought it was a book about a man who threw parties. I read it again at twenty-three and found it a book about a man who could not stop looking backwards. Nothing in the text had changed. Every sentence was where I had left it. Yet the novel had altered completely, and the alteration was not in the pages but in the person holding them.

This is the ordinary miracle of rereading, and it is worth pausing over because it contradicts something we usually assume about books. We speak of a text as fixed, and materially it is: the words are identical in every copy, and no amount of enthusiasm on the reader's part will add a sentence. But meaning is not stored in the text the way water is stored in a vessel. It is produced in the encounter, and the encounter involves two parties, only one of whom is printed and bound. The other arrives with a history — a set of losses, a changed vocabulary, a new capacity to notice a particular kind of pain — and that history is what the book is actually read against.

The practical consequence is that a book can be a measuring instrument. Pick up something you read at fifteen and the experience is uncannily informative, though not always flattering. Passages you once underlined seem overwrought. A character you found villainous now seems merely tired. A scene that took three pages and meant nothing to you at the time now stops you for an hour, because you have since learned what it costs to lose something. This is not a failure of your younger judgement; it is evidence that judgement is a thing that grows, and that the growth is invisible until something external holds a record of it. The book is that record. It remembers what you were like when you first met it.

There is a discipline in this that is easy to miss. Reading widely is one pleasure; reading deeply, and returning, is a different one, and it produces a different kind of know-

ledge. A student who has read a hundred books once has been introduced to a hundred worlds and has lived in none of them. A student who has read ten books three times has learned how a book works — how a writer builds a scene, withholds a fact, arranges a paragraph so that its final sentence lands — and that knowledge transfers. It is the difference between visiting a city and knowing it. And it is available to anyone with a library card and the willingness to be bored by a second reading before the rewards begin.

In a country where the examination syllabus is heavy and time is scarce, this argument can sound like a luxury. It is not. The capacity to revise a judgement, to notice that one has changed one's mind, and to hold two readings of the same thing in view at once — these are the habits of mind a democracy needs and a working life requires. They are also, not incidentally, the habits that produce a good essay, because an essay is simply a record of a mind moving from one position to another while someone watches.

I still have the copy I read at seventeen. The pencil marks are embarrassing, and the margins are full of a boy who was certain of things. I keep it because it is the only object I own that documents what I was thinking before I learned to think differently. A library is often described as a collection of books. Mine has begun, quietly, to function as a collection of earlier selves — and the shelf, unlike memory, does not tidy itself up to flatter me.

We do not read a great book once. We read it at intervals, and each time it tells us something we did not ask about: not what the author meant, but who we have become since we last listened.

Before You Write

A checklist to run in the five minutes before an examination essay, and the five minutes after.

IN THE PLANNING MINUTES

- [ ] Underline the operative words in the question — *discuss, argue, examine, to what extent*. Each demands a different shape of answer.
- [ ] Write your thesis in one sentence on the rough sheet. If you cannot, you do not yet have an essay.
- [ ] List three or four body points and check that they advance the thesis rather than merely sit beside it.
- [ ] Decide the order: does each paragraph depend on the previous one?
- [ ] Choose one concrete Nepali example and one wider example. Specific evidence is what separates a good essay from a fluent one.

WHILE WRITING

- [ ] Open with an image, a fact or a small scene — never with a definition.
- [ ] State the thesis at the end of the introduction, clearly enough that an examiner could quote it.
- [ ] Begin every body paragraph with a topic sentence that makes a claim, not an announcement.
- [ ] Analyse your evidence. A statistic dropped into a paragraph and left unexamined earns nothing.
- [ ] Concede one point fairly. An essay that admits nothing reads as if it has not thought.
- [ ] Keep sentences varied: a short sentence after two long ones lands harder than a third long one.
- [ ] Watch the clock at the halfway mark; if you are still on body paragraph two, compress.

IN THE FINAL MINUTES

- [ ] Check subject–verb agreement in every sentence longer than two lines.
- [ ] Check tense consistency: an essay that drifts between present and past reads as careless.
- [ ] Confirm the conclusion restates the thesis without repeating the introduction word for word.
- [ ] Count the words. Being far under the limit costs content marks; far over costs time.
- [ ] Make sure the paragraphs are visible on the page. An examiner should see the argument's shape before reading a word of it.

A NOTE ON USING THESE ESSAYS

The twelve essays in this collection are models, not answers. No examiner will set these titles, and an essay reproduced from memory will not fit the question actually asked. What transfers is the architecture: the hook that earns attention, the thesis that commits to a position, the body paragraphs that build rather than accumulate, and the conclusion that returns and widens. Read one essay for its shape, then write your own on a topic you have not seen before. That is the only practice that improves the score.

Each essay also models a different relationship to its subject — argumentative, discursive, reflective — because the NEB free-writing task does not always ask you to persuade. Read the mode line beneath each title and notice how it changes the voice: the argumentative essays press a claim, the discursive ones weigh competing positions before settling, and the reflective essay thinks aloud while remaining controlled.

COLOPHON

Set in EB Garamond for body text and Inter for headings and apparatus. A4, printed margins 25 mm top, 24 mm bottom, 38 mm fore-edge. Twelve essays, one guide, one marking note.